

The Song of the Severed Branch

"Before my blood had a name..."

"Before the Ten Brinken stood at the brink of death..."

"Before the Gegners bound what could not be held..."

"There was the tree."

"Yggdrasil."

"And there was the end."

"Ragnarök came."

"The wolves ran beneath the sky."

"The fires rose."

"The old oaths were fulfilled."

"The gods walked toward the fate written for them."

"The world was meant to end."

"But Odin looked upon the roots of Yggdrasil..."

"And he saw what waited beneath them."

"Not only death."

"Not only ruin."

"But another beginning."

"A new tree waited to rise through the bones of the old."

"A new world waited to be born from the corpse of the first."

"And Odin would not allow it."

"There were many branches of the great tree."

"Many worlds."

"Many paths where the last children of the gods still stood."

"Some say he chose the branch where the greatest number survived."

"Some say he chose the branch where Baldur still walked..."

"Where Freya still breathed..."

"No one living remembers the truth."

"Only that Odin reached for the tree..."

"And cut."

"A single branch fell away from Yggdrasil."

"A piece of the old world, severed from its father."

"And that branch did not die."

"It began again."

"That branch became Midgard anew."

"The nine worlds remained."

"The roots remained."

"The old names remained."

"But the Aesir were gone."

"And those who survived did not celebrate their survival."

"They mourned."

"They wept."

"They called out to those who would never answer."

"Some begged the heavens to take them."

"Some begged the earth to swallow them."

"Some sought the end that had already been denied them."

"But they were gods."

"And gods do not always receive the mercy they ask for."

"So they endured."

"Then Líf and Lífþrasir walked upon Midgard."

"And from them came mankind once more."

"The empty lands filled with footsteps."

"The silent valleys filled with voices."

"The gods continued."

"And they carried only one promise with them:"

"When their own end finally came..."

"perhaps Odin's halls would open once more."

"But Freya held half the dead."

"And that was when the gods learned the wound in their new world."

"At first they thought only a few souls had remained."

"A few ghosts."

"A few memories unwilling to fade."

"But they were wrong."

"All the dead remained."

"Because the new world had no wall between what lived..."

"and what had already ended."

"There was no true separation."

"Some gods feared it."

"Some hated it."

"And some..."

"some found comfort in never losing what they loved."

"Baldur needed a wife."

"So he took Freya."

"And the remaining gods turned toward one another."

"The children of gods became companions to the children of gods."

"Blood sought blood."

"Survivors sought survivors."

"And from that union of the old and the new..."

"seven great houses were born."

"They were not Aesir."

"They were not human."

"They were something that had never existed before."

"The Ten Brinken came from Baldur and Freya."

"The Gegner came from Vidarr and the daughter of Sól."

"The tribes carried the blood of gods who had ended..."

"and gods who had endured."

"They forged a world from what remained."

"But Freya was not happy beside Baldur."

"And Baldur did not care enough to notice."

"When Vidarr's wife rose into the sky..."

"Vidarr offered Freya what Baldur would not."

"A place beside him."

"A quiet place."

"A place where she did not have to pretend she was not alone."

"And so the Gegners became close to the dead Freya."

"As close as the Ten Brinken."

"And that bond remained."

"One of many threads binding the two houses together."

"Then came the day Freya entered the old river."

"The river that remembered what the world had forgotten."

"And something beneath the waters saw her."

"The world looked upon it..."

"and called it ugly."

"The world looked upon it..."

"and called it wrong."

"But Freya did not see a monster."

"She saw hunger."

"She saw instinct."

"She saw something that had no need to pretend."

"It was not cruel."

"It was not kind."

"It simply was."

"And to Freya..."

"it felt like the old gods."

"It felt like home."

"The world gave him many names."

"The First Father."

"The Blood Before Death."

"The First Beast."

"The Unforgotten Ancestor."

"The Root of Two Houses."

"The Father Beneath Separation."

"The One Who Still Remembers."

"Grandfather of the Ancient Blood."

"And from him came the blood of two houses."

"The blood that would never fully forget the world before."

"For generations, Freya and the First Father continued their union."

"Until even the oldest rivers must reach their end."

"And Nidr..."

"Nidr, who understood the wound of separation better than any..."

"shaped the first Alraune from the Father's blood."

"And so it continued."

"For thousands of years."

"Until the final time Freya and the First Father came together..."

"And from that union came the next turning of the blood."

"From Unn came Audun."

"From Audun came Gudrun."

"From Gudrun came Sigrún."

"From Sigrún came Inge."

"And from Inge came Tómauðr."

"But Tómauðr would not remain Tómauðr."

"Her husband refused her hand unless she carried another name."

"And so she became Auðr."

"And from Auðr came the solstice twins."

"Born beneath the turning of the year."

"Born between darkness and returning light."

"One would become the Alraune known as..."

"Livrún."

"The Exceptional One."

"And the other..."

"Freki."

"The Ravenous Fox."
